

to a mobile phone rather than being a completely stand alone device. Something that would pretty much become the norm in the future.

Kickstarting the category

2013 was the year we finally saw something akin to modern smartwatches, and it did not come from any established brands. A little company called Pebble started a crowdfunding campaign on Kickstarter for a new type of wearable device. This would offer features like smartphone notifications, straightforward pairing and a simple design.

However, one of its most notable features was the ability to download and install apps from the internet. This gave it the flexibility needed to take on multiple roles depending on the user's taste. While it wasn't perfect, the smartwatch had arrived.

Google it

Soon enough, the big boys wanted a slice of the pie. Google was among the first with its Android Wear (now Wear OS) line of devices. In 2014, the LG G Watch and Samsung Gear Live became the first Android Wear powered devices. This was followed shortly after by the Moto 360. Both these devices offered colour screens, multiple watch faces and an app store. This was just the start as Huawei, Asus and Sony would launch their own smartwatches powered by Android Wear.



LG G Watch

Apple on your... wrist?

The same year, Apple unveiled its own take on the smartwatch. Simply

called Apple Watch, it took the industry by storm. Unlike Pebble or Google's attempts, Apple understood that a watch is also a fashion accessory. Which is why it released multiple different straps so that the users could pick one based on their taste. Of course, the design isn't the only reason for the success of the Watch. The device was also simple to use. Apple figured that traditional touch-based gestures that are used on a smartphone were unsuited for the tiny display of a watch. So it designed a system where users could interact via a combination of touch, button and a rotatable crown. Now here have we heard that before? Whether you like it or not, the Apple Watch range is still the benchmark when it comes to smartwatches.

Don't forget to exercise

Here, we take a short detour and talk about fitness trackers. Around 2010, we started to see fitness-centric devices being released into the market. Most notable of these manufacturers was Fitbit. Earliest Fitbit devices were clipped on to your pocket and would track metrics like steps, pace and so forth. Things changed when manufacturers switched to a wristband form-factor and added a tiny display to show things like the time, steps taken, and more. This added more usability to the tracker.

The overall simplicity of fitness trackers meant that they were considerably cheaper than full blown smartwatches. This made them more accessible to most users who wanted to try out a smart wearable device. In India, Xiaomi made quite a splash in the market with its Mi Band series of wearables. Fitness trackers were also making waves in the more premium end of the market as well. Devices from companies like Garmin and Fitbit offered extremely accurate activity tracking by employing a range of sensors to track a host of activities.

In the quest to offer as much as possible to buyers, the line between smartwatches and fitness trackers is getting blurred. Most trackers now

offer basic smartwatch-like features such as smartphone notifications, multiple watch faces, and more. Meanwhile, smartwatches now tout fitness and health-centric features as part of their key selling points.



Apple Watch Series 1

Oops...

Around the 2010's, someone had an interesting idea. Why go through all the bother of making a smartwatch, which they could just shrink down the smartphone. As such, we got the watch phone, a device that was not good at being either a watch or a phone. Notable examples include the Samsung S9110 and the Burg watch phones. There were even some Indian examples like the Intex iRist and the Spice Smart Pulse M9010. These gadgets failed as either they were too bulky, lacked key features or the UI was convoluted to use on a tiny display. In hindsight, it's pretty obvious why it died. If people wanted a small,



Fitbit Zip